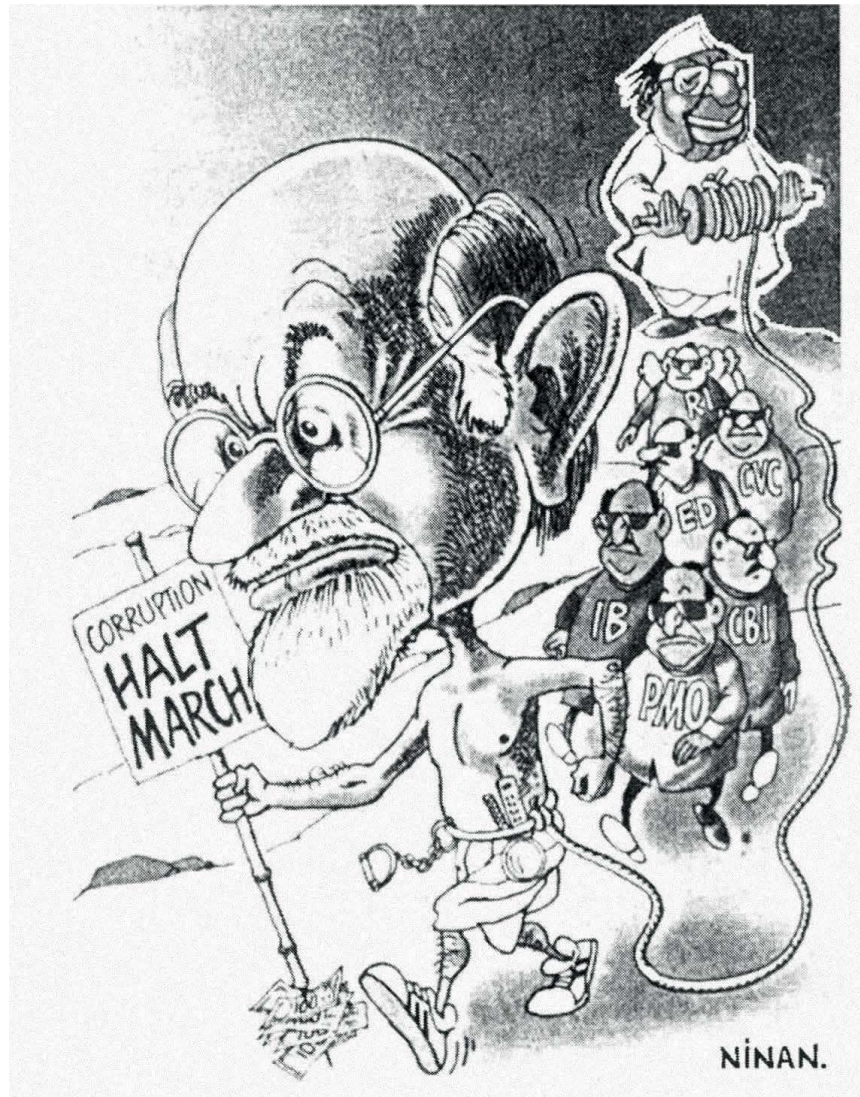


DANDA MARCH
I.K. Gujral's plan to weed out corruption may have been noble, but the netas did not make it easy. A 1997 INDIA TODAY cartoon by Ajit Ninan

THE EXPOSÉ ON THE JAIN COMMISSION ACCELERATED THE AVALANCHE THAT FORCED GUJRAL TO RESIGN, AFFIRMING OUR ROLE IN REVEALING THE REALITIES OF FRAGILE REGIMES

our magazine occupied opulent living rooms and enlightened elite minds. As it evolved into a national messenger of complex messages, politics dominated our pages, probing the post-Narasimha Rao churn, Congress's crumbling clout, and the BJP's burgeoning boldness.

So, when Deve Gowda's 1996 government grappled with grassroots grievances and economic enigmas, we sensed the shifting sands. Let me share an anecdote that illuminates our acumen. In May 1997, our exposé on corruption in the fodder scam foreshadowed the fiasco that later engulfed Lalu Prasad Yadav's Bihar bastion, hinting at the fragility of coalitions. This prescience showed that we had a hand on the pulse of a polity in peril. By mid-1997, amid Gujral's genteel governance emphasising external equilibrium, INDIA TODAY went through an epochal evolution: shifting from fortnightly to weekly on June 2, 1997, after much internal introspection. The switch led to a surge, as print orders proliferated. By the early 2000s, National Readership Survey (NRS) data revealed that we had some 8 million readers, dwarfing rivals despite a dip in overall magazine metrics.

INDIA TODAY radiated credibility and market mastery, a mix of depth and dynamism that drew a diverse demographic of readers. Our first cover as a weekly (dated June 9, 1997) was on 'King Kesri', and featured then Congress president Sitaram Kesri alongside a panoramic picture of the party's working committee (CWC) members—a vignette of vested interests and veiled ambitions. The audacious artwork not only captured Kesri's kingmaker clout in toppling Gowda and installing Gujral but also reflected the power the magazine wielded within the political power system. Our special issues spotlighted societal shifts: the bold 'Sex Survey' editions in the late 1990s demystified taboos, delving into desires and dilemmas amid liberalisation's loosening norms, while our 'Best Colleges' rankings were targeted at our tenacious youth and their anxious parents. 'Person of the Year' and end-of-year extravaganzas encapsulated eras, celebrating the vision of stalwarts like Vajpayee or critiquing coalition conundrums.

Our investigative edge also often engineered change. A pivotal anecdote underscores this: the tenacious reporting on the Jain Commission inquiry into Rajiv Gandhi's assassination, particularly the November 1997 cover story, 'Damning Revelations', on the interim report indicting the DMK for colluding with the LTTE, amplified the allegations. The exposé on the Jain Commission accelerated the avalanche that forced Gujral to resign, reaffirming our role in revealing the realities of fragile regimes. The late